

This, then, is the story of how I chose my road to success and how I traveled it from my wildcatting days in the Oklahoma oil fields, of how I've built my business and made my fortune. To it, I would like to add a brief, highly personal—

and mildly rueful—footnote.

For years I had managed—at least on the whole—to avoid personal publicity. Or rather, since I did nothing either to seek or evade it, I suppose it would be more accurate to say that personal publicity avoided me. This state of peaceful near-anonymity ended suddenly and forever in October 1957, when *Fortune* magazine published an article listing the wealthiest people in the United States. My name headed the list, and the article labeled me a billionaire and "The Richest Man in America."

Subsequently, other publications gave me the even more grandiloquent title of "The Richest Man in the World."

Since then, I've been besieged by requests to reveal exactly how much money I have. I'm seldom believed when I reply in all honesty that I don't know, that there is no way I *can* know. Most of my wealth is invested in the businesses I own or control; I make no claims about the extent of my wealth and I really don't care how rich I am.

Today, the companies are thriving, and they're carrying out ambitious programs for further expansion. My primary concern and main interest lie in making certain that these companies continue to grow so that they can provide more employment and produce more goods and services for the benefit of all. My associates and I are convinced that the

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over-all economic trend is up and that despite the alarums and fears plaguing our era, the world is on the threshold of a prosperity greater than any in its history.

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